



CENTRAL AFRICAN REPUBLIC

Capital city: Bangui

Area: 240,530 sq miles (622,980 sq km)

Population: 3,900,000

Official language: French

Major religions: traditional beliefs 60%, Christian 35%, Muslim 5%

Government: Transitional government

Currency: CFA franc

Adult literacy rate: 49%

Life expectancy: 42 years

People per doctor: 25,000

Televisions: 5 per 1,000 people

EQUATORIAL GUINEA

Capital city: Malabo

Area: 10,830 sq miles (28,050 sq km)

Population: 494,000

Official language: Spanish, French

Major religions: Christian 90%, other 10%

Government: Multiparty democracy

Currency: CFA franc

Adult literacy rate: 84%

Life expectancy: 52 years

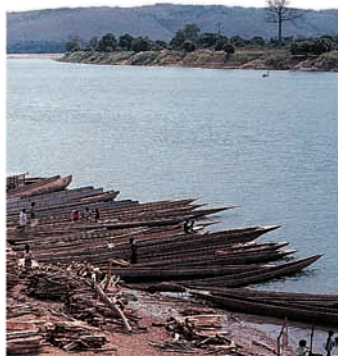
People per doctor: 5,000

Televisions: 10 per 1,000 people

CENTRAL AFRICAN REPUBLIC

SITUATED AT THE CORE OF AFRICA, the north of the Central African Republic (CAR) is arid, while lush rain forest covers the south. Drought and political unrest have caused great problems here. In 1965, Emperor Bokassa began a 14-year reign of terror, which was followed by military dictatorship. Today the country remains under military rule, although

the government has pledged to introduce democracy.



RIVER ROUTES

The CAR is surrounded by land and has no railroad system and few well-surfaced roads, so its rivers are vital for transportation and trade. Nearly three-quarters of trading goods are shipped down the 4,350 miles (7,000 km) of inland waterways. Many goods travel to Brazzaville in Congo. Here they are loaded onto trains and taken to the Atlantic coast.



This woman is sifting diamonds from a riverbed.

INDUSTRY

A large part of the country's income comes from diamonds. There is potential for developing other industries, too, since gold, iron ore, copper, and uranium are also found here. Flooding caused by heavy seasonal rains, however, is a constant threat to any kind of mining.

PYGMIES

Small huts made from banana leaves are found deep in the country's rain forests. These are the homes of a people known as pygmies, called this because they rarely grow taller than about 5 ft (1.5 m). Pygmies are hunter-gatherers, living on food collected from the rain forest. They are a shining example of people living in harmony with the natural world, not damaging the environment.

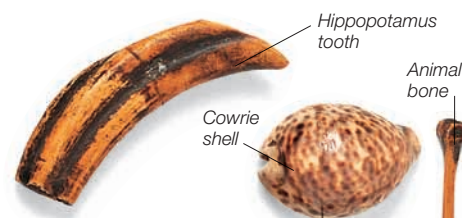


EQUATORIAL GUINEA

THE ECONOMY AND PEOPLE of Equatorial Guinea have suffered badly because of brutal leadership. Macias Nguema ruled as a cruel dictator during the 1970s, but a more moderate government came to power in the 1990s. This tiny, beautiful country, which includes five islands, is now working hard to build its economy.

FARMING

Although the hot climate and fertile volcanic soil of the largest island, Bioko, are perfect for growing crops, there are few good roads and the workforce is unskilled. Concentrating on growing cocoa for export has left little land for people to grow food for themselves.



Hippopotamus tooth

Cowrie shell

Animal bone

TRADITIONAL MEDICINE

Traditional medicine is still widely practiced in Africa. Animal bones, shells, and wooden sticks are used in public healing ceremonies. The healer will often sing and dance around the patient, using chants to cry out to the spirits for help.

Tree root

Find out more

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